

MASK SLIP

A Feature Screenplay — Elevated Thriller / Horror

Story & Screenplay by Zoe Miller

Based on her original song “The Mask”

When her estranged younger sister vanishes into an upstate wellness retreat, a sound healer who spent four years surviving a narcissist of her own goes undercover inside the compound — and has to decide whether the charismatic founder's hold over dozens of followers is a supernatural hunger passed down four generations, or simply the most ordinary evil this country produces, dressed in incense and good lighting, before her sister becomes its next “Primary Supply.”

THE HOOK

MASK SLIP uses the machinery of horror — a gated compound, masked rituals, a possibly-supernatural entity — to literalize the actual psychology of narcissistic abuse: DARVO (Deny, Attack, Reverse Victim and Offender), love-bombing followed by isolation, and “flying monkeys” — the weaponized kindness of a community that surrounds a target with warmth until compliance looks like healing.

It subverts genre expectation at the climax: the protagonist does not defeat the entity with force. She is a Lightworker who alchemizes rather than destroys — the turn happens when she stops performing fear and shame for an audience, and the story refuses, deliberately, to ever confirm whether what she faced down was literal or psychological. That ambiguity is load-bearing, not a loose end: it is the same disorientation survivors of covert abuse actually describe.

SYNOPSIS

WREN MERCER, a sound healer in her early thirties, gets a garbled, frightened voicemail from her younger sister IVY, who has joined the Aurelia Circle, a wellness retreat upstate run by the magnetic RAFE AURELIO and his wife SELAH. Wren's mentor, NAN CASSIDY, lost her own daughter to an earlier version of the same organization in 1994 and hands Wren an old mirror pendant — not a weapon, just something that won't let her be gaslit out of what she already knows.

Inside the gates, Wren finds a community that is genuinely, maddeningly both: real healing and real predation, running on the same machinery. A groundskeeper named JONAH becomes an ally; a demoted member named PIPER becomes an unlikely one. As Wren digs — financial fraud old enough to prosecute, a ledger tracking members as “Supply” and “Primary,” a lineage of masked founders stretching back to 1911 — she finds her sister's initial already penciled in as the next candidate for a role that swallowed the last woman who held it whole.

The back half plays out the central question the film never answers: is Rafe hosting something ancient and hungry, or is he simply an unusually potent concentration of grandiose narcissism, feeding off a room built to worship him? Wren's confrontation, when it comes, isn't a fight. It's a refusal — to perform fear, to perform shame, to give the room (or the thing behind it) an audience — and the film lets us feel how uncertain even she is about whether that's psychology or something older, right up to its final, unresolved image.

COMPARABLE TITLES & POSITIONING

Hereditary's refusal to resolve the entity-or-psychology question, The Invitation's slow-burn dread of infiltrating a compound from the inside, and Martha Marcy May Marlene's grounded, unsentimental cult psychology — with the folk-horror communal dread of Midsommar and the restrained ambiguity of Sound of My Voice.

KEY CHARACTERS

WREN MERCER (lead)

Sound healer, early 30s. A survivor of a four-year relationship with a covert narcissist (“Derek,” unseen), which trained the exact eye she now uses to read the Circle. Her arc is not learning to fight — it’s learning that refusing to perform for an audience is its own kind of power.

IVY MERCER

Wren’s younger sister, drawn in by being “picked first” for the first time in her life. Being groomed, without her knowledge, as the next “Primary Supply.”

RAFE AURELIO

40s, founder of the Aurelia Circle. Grandiose-narcissist charisma turned up to the point of the uncanny; possibly a vessel for something that has outlived four generations of his family. The film never tells you which.

SELAH AURELIO

40s, co-founder. Covert-narcissist enabler with genuine, unnerving self-awareness — the character most likely to say a true thing in the same breath as a manipulative one.

NAN CASSIDY

70s, Wren’s mentor. Lost her daughter to the organization’s earlier form in 1994 and has spent thirty years unable to decide whether what took her was literal or not — and has made peace with not knowing.

FRANCHISE POTENTIAL

The Aurelia Circle is explicitly established, in-story, as one of at least nine “sister circles” nationally, and the closing scene plants the pattern resurfacing under a new name. MASK SLIP is built to stand alone as a single feature, and to seed a mythology that can extend further — see the attached Feature Bible for the full packaging case.

ABOUT THE WRITER

Zoe Miller is a WGA/WGAE television writer (The Blacklist) and songwriter. MASK SLIP is adapted from her original song of the same thematic DNA, “The Mask” — music she owns outright, and a real packaging asset for trailer and marketing use.

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